



PLASTIC sheeting covers a hillside behind a home on Via Cresta near fire-ravaged slopes in Pacific Palisades before the latest rainstorm. Photographs by GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

Corps won't test soil after cleanup

Removing top six inches is enough, engineering service says, breaking with traditional safeguards.

By TONY BRISCOE

The U.S. Army Corps of Engineers said Wednesday that it won't order soil testing at properties damaged by the Eaton and Palisades fires after they have been cleaned by private federal contractors — breaking with a long-standing safeguard to ensure no lingering contamination is left behind after wildfires.

Federal and state agencies have called for soil samples to be collected and analyzed at homes and schools cleaned by work crews after nearly every major wildfire in California for the last two decades.

The process, known as confirmation sampling, is intended to verify that the soil at these properties no longer harbors toxic chemicals above the state's clean-up standards once toxic-laden ash and rubble are removed, along with up to six inches of topsoil.

But now, on the heels of the most costly wildfires in the state's history, Army Corps officials are saying that excavating six inches of topsoil is enough to rid fire-devastated properties of hazardous pollution.

At a news conference in downtown Los Angeles on Wednesday, Army Corps Col. Eric Swenson explained the decision by saying soil sampling wasn't authorized in this disaster response.

"When the state does a request for direct federal assistance ... they make that request of [the Federal Emergency Management Agency]," Swenson said. "And we get brought on to do a specific scope. And so these are the limits of what we can do under this disaster."

The Army Corps is told, [See Soil testing, A12]

Fears rise in Trump versus courts

President fights judicial orders and stirs a debate over whether the U.S. is in a constitutional crisis.

By KEVIN RECTOR, DAVID G. SAVAGE AND SONJA SHARP

WASHINGTON — A week after winning a court order requiring the Trump administration to unfreeze billions of dollars in federal funding, California and other states were back in court Friday to ask the judge to intervene once more, arguing the administration hadn't complied with the order.

Although it was "imaginable" that thawing the freeze would take some time, there was "no world" in which the administration could be seen as complying with the court's order, given the amount of funding that still appeared frozen a week later, the states argued.

The Trump administration, in response, said that wasn't true. It said that federal agencies had "worked diligently to assure compliance," and that no additional court enforcement was necessary as it appealed the judge's order.

The dispute was one of many playing out in federal courts across the country in recent days as states, nonprofits, schools, doctors, unions, federal employees, immigrants, individual citizens and others have rushed to challenge a wave of unilateral and legally dubious actions by the Trump administration to reshape the federal government.

It was also front and center in a growing debate around the power of the federal courts to rein in the president if and when he violates the law — particularly given that the Republicans [See Courts, A6]

Rain raises risk of debris flows in burn areas

By HANNAH FRY AND RONG-GONG LIN II

With the most powerful rainstorm of the season set to soak Southern California on Thursday, the first assessment of mudslide danger since the January firestorms shows that the Pacific Palisades and the Altadena burn areas both face significantly heightened risk of debris flows in the coming days and months.

In the San Gabriel Valley, where the Eaton fire charred a deadly and devastating path — leveling more than 9,400 structures including many homes — a state report noted that there's a high likelihood that heavy rain could generate large, damaging postfire flooding and debris flows.

On the Westside, where the Palisades fire began Jan. 7, there's a greater risk of flooding and rockslides than debris flows. But the reports — issued by the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection and the California Department of Conservation — say in both areas the fires have left wide swaths of land, including many neighborhoods, at risk for significant additional damage in the next several years.

The reports act as a blueprint for [See Debris, A12]

In reports, two state agencies outline potential dangers from this week's three-day storm and others ahead for Pacific Palisades, Altadena



WORKERS WITH Arizona Pipeline Co. weld shut abandoned natural gas lines Wednesday outside a fire-damaged home in Pacific Palisades.

The '51st state'? Canada says no, thank you. Same goes for American goods

National boycott of U.S. products gains ground after Trump turns longtime ally into a punching bag.

By KATE LINTHICUM AND DENIS CALNAN

TORONTO — Shopping for groceries the other afternoon at his neighborhood supermarket here, Victor Meunier reached for a head of broccoli — then reconsidered. It had been imported from the United States.

Meunier ditched the broccoli and reached for a package of mushrooms with a different label: "Product of Canada."

It was a small act of resistance against the Trump administration and its sud-

den depending of the long-time alliance between the two nations.

Since taking office last month, President Trump has turned Canada into a punching bag, threatening hefty tariffs on its goods while insisting that he is serious when he says that he wants to annex the country to make it America's "51st state."

"They would be much better off," Trump said of Canadians a few days ago, adding that Canada is "not viable as a country" without U.S. trade.

Outraged by such talk from a nation that is supposed to be their closest friend, normally mild-mannered Canadians have been scrapping beach trips to Florida, booing the U.S. anthem when it plays before NHL and NBA games and [See Canada, A4]

Gabbard wins confirmation

After initial GOP concerns, all Republican senators but one support her as intelligence chief. NATION, A5

Ban is proposed on dog brokers

Legislators want to shut down a pipeline to the state from puppy mills in the Midwest. CALIFORNIA, B1

Beverly Hills tower proposed

The \$450-million condo high-rise would include 249 units and soar 34 stories. BUSINESS, A8

Weather

Cool with downpours. L.A. Basin: 60/52. B6

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Inflation worsened in January as the cost of groceries, gas climbed

Consumer price index rose 3%, data show. Acceleration is likely to bolster Fed resolve to delay rate cuts.

By CHRISTOPHER RUGABER

WASHINGTON — U.S. inflation accelerated last month as the cost of groceries, gas and used cars rose, a disappointment for families and businesses struggling with higher costs and likely underscoring the Federal Reserve's resolve to delay any further interest rate cuts.

The consumer price index increased 3% in January from a year earlier, Wednesday's report from the Labor Department showed, up

from a 2.9% rise the previous month. Inflation increased from a 3 1/2-year low of 2.4% in September.

The figures show that inflation has remained stubbornly above the Fed's 2% target for roughly the last six months, after it fell steadily for about a year and a half. Elevated prices created a major political problem for former President Biden. President Trump pledged to reduce prices in last year's campaign, though most economists worry that his many proposed tariffs could at least temporarily increase costs.

The unexpected boost in inflation could dampen some of the business enthusiasm that arose after Trump's election on promises to reduce regulation and cut taxes. The Dow fell 225 points Wednesday. Bond [See Inflation, A9]



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